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FROM WATCHING ON THE SIDELINES TO OWNING THE FIELD

How Deepika went from watching hockey as a child to becoming one of India's most promising forwards and a **rising drag-flick** specialist.

Nihit Sachdeva

nihit.s@thehindu.co.in

"Hockey or nothing." For Deepika, the decision was swift. After all, she was just an eight-year-old child.

It didn't matter that she didn't know the name of the sport or its basics. Watching a group of girls training at a hockey stadium on her way to the wrestling arena at the SAI Centre in Hisar was enough. She had made up her mind.

"When the girls were passing the

ball to each other, I didn't even know it was called passing. They were encouraging one another, saying, 'Come on! I liked that,' the 21-year-old told *Sportstar*.

When she returned home, she told her father, "*Mujhe khelni hai toh hockey hi khelni hai, nahin toh koi aur sport mein jaana hi nahin hai* (If I am to play a sport, it will be hockey; otherwise, I won't play anything)."

Deepika's father, grandfather, and cousins had all participated in wrestling and kabaddi at some point. Sending her with her brother for wrestling practice was a natural step in continuing the family tradition.

But for now, her father decided the wrestling mat could wait. He approached coach Azad Singh Malik and asked if his daughter could play hockey at the same ground where she had first witnessed the game. Given her small stature and young age, Malik initially refused to train her. However, after her father's persistent requests, he allowed her to sit on a wooden bench and observe the sessions.

For three days, Deepika watched the other girls play before Malik finally asked, "*Hockey khelni hai?* (Do you want to play hockey?)"

That girl from Haryana, who first